They proclaimed themselves a National Assembly and gathering on a tennis court after the King had cleared them out of their hall, swore on oath not to disperse until he gave them a constitution. Thus began the revolution of 1789 in France.

Causes of the Outbreak

Political


Louis XVI

Louis XV succeeded his great-grandfather Louis XIV and reigned for fifty nine years. He learnt no lesson that the king is not above law but bound by law from the English Revolution and the beheading of the King Charles I. In 1774 he was succeeded by his grandson Louis XVI. He was entirely under the influence of his wife Marie Antoinette, who believed, more than the King, in the Divine Right Theory of Kingship - the theory that the king was representative of god on earth and therefore for all his actions he was accountable only to god and not to anybody else. Both the King and the Queen were hated by the people.

Economic

On the eve of the French revolution France was going through a period of economic crisis. The French treasury was bankrupt because of its involvement in the Seven Years War that ended in defeat. French participation in the American War of Independence made the financial condition worse. The luxurious lifestyle of the royalty and nobles in Versailles court, in contrast to the grinding poverty of the common people, made the people accept the new ideologies of French philosophers of the eighteenth century. The Finance Ministers of the King, Turgot, Necker, Calonne and Brienne one after the other suggested reduction of royal expenditure and taxation of the first two Estates - the nobles and the clergy. Their advice was not only disregarded but they themselves were dismissed from service. To meet the resource crunch the government borrowed heavily resulting in a huge fiscal deficit. Nearly half the revenue went towards payment of interest for the loans. Under the circumstances, the French monarch Louis XVI was forced to convene the Estate-General, the combined body of three estates comprising nobles, clergy and commoners respectively.

Social

The condition of the already impoverished peasants worsened due to a series of bad harvests. It resulted in the rise of the price of bread. The peasants of the countryside and the labourers and artisans of the towns were the worst affected. There were hunger riots at the beginning of the reign of Louis XVI. They were followed later by fresh peasant risings. A vast number of people had become professional beggars. It was officially declared in 1777 that there were eleven lakhs of beggars in France. The peasants were hungry not only for food, but were also hungry for land. They hated the nobles and the clergy because they enjoyed many privileges, notably exemption from taxation.

The clergy, despite being a minority, numbering only about 130,000, occupied a preeminent position in France. They collected *tithe* (one tenth of the annual produce or earnings) from the common people. The nobility, also a minority, numbering about 110,000, was a landowning class enjoying feudal rights. They collected feudal dues from the peasants. Their land was tilled by the peasants. The farm produce of the peasants had to be processed in the mills of the feudal lord. The traditional hereditary nobles known as *nobles of the sword* enjoyed hunting rights. They were against the rising middle class (bourgeoisie) or a new class of nobility, the status that was conferred by the king for their services. These nobles were known as *nobles of the robe.*

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